

# Shadow Projection and Failure of Local Closure: A Structural Model of Abusive Relationship Dynamics

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## Abstract

Abusive relationships are often described in psychological terms such as trauma bonding, attachment dysfunction, codependency, or maladaptive reinforcement. While these descriptions capture important behavioral aspects of the phenomenon, they do not fully explain why certain relational structures exhibit remarkable stability despite producing suffering for both participants.

This paper proposes a structural interpretation based on the Theory of Axiomatic Necessity (TNA). We argue that abusive dynamics emerge when psychological functions that should be integrated within an individual are externalized into another person. Through the mechanism traditionally described by Jung as shadow projection, individuals attempt to achieve local psychological closure by using another person as a carrier of disowned functions.

The resulting relationship temporarily stabilizes both participants, but this stability depends upon an externalized boundary condition. The relationship therefore exhibits what TNA identifies as Failure of Local Closure: an inability of a system to generate internally the conditions required for its own coherence.

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## 1. Introduction

One of the most puzzling aspects of abusive relationships is their persistence.

Observers often assume that suffering should naturally lead to separation. Yet many destructive relationships display remarkable durability despite repeated cycles of conflict, violence, humiliation, reconciliation, and relapse.

Traditional explanations focus on:

- Attachment styles

- Childhood trauma
- Economic dependence
- Reinforcement cycles
- Neurochemical bonding

While these factors contribute to the phenomenon, they do not fully explain why the relationship frequently appears psychologically necessary to both participants.

This paper proposes that abusive dynamics can be understood as a structural phenomenon generated by the externalization of psychological functions.

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## 2. Jungian Shadow as Structural Deficit

Carl Jung introduced the concept of the Shadow as the collection of psychological contents excluded from conscious identity.

The Shadow typically contains qualities that the individual refuses to acknowledge as part of the self:

- Aggression
- Power
- Vulnerability
- Dependence
- Sexuality
- Anger
- Autonomy

The individual constructs a conscious persona while relegating incompatible functions to the unconscious.

This process creates an asymmetry.

The person remains operationally functional, but certain psychological capacities become inaccessible through conscious self-regulation.

The result is a structurally incomplete system.

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### 3. Projection as Externalization

When a function cannot be integrated internally, it is frequently projected externally.

The individual begins to perceive in another person precisely those capacities that have been rejected within the self.

For example:

A highly compliant individual may project strength, aggression, and authority onto a dominant partner.

A highly controlling individual may project vulnerability, dependence, and emotional fragility onto a submissive partner.

The attraction is not accidental.

Each individual encounters in the other an external representation of a missing psychological function.

The relationship therefore becomes a mechanism for compensating internal incompleteness.

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### 4. The Structural Fit of Abuse

Consider a simplified example.

A compliant partner suppresses:

- Anger
- Assertiveness
- Boundary-setting
- Self-prioritization

These functions become part of the Shadow.

The abusive partner openly expresses:

- Domination
- Aggression
- Control

- Boundary enforcement

The compliant partner experiences unconscious attraction because the abusive partner embodies disowned capacities.

Simultaneously, the abusive partner may suppress:

- Dependency
- Fear
- Emotional vulnerability
- Abandonment anxiety

These traits become projected onto the compliant partner.

Each participant therefore uses the other as a psychological carrier of rejected functions.

The relationship forms a complementary structure.

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## 5. Failure of Local Closure

Within TNA, a system exhibits Failure of Local Closure when it cannot internally generate the conditions required for its own coherence.

The individual requires a function F.

However, F is not accessible internally.

The individual therefore imports F from outside the system.

Formally:

Psychological State → Missing Function → External Carrier

The relationship becomes the boundary condition that allows temporary stabilization.

The missing function is not integrated.

It is outsourced.

The apparent stability of the relationship is therefore achieved through structural dependence.

## 6. The Cycle of Abuse

The abusive cycle emerges because the externalized solution cannot permanently resolve the underlying deficit.

The process typically unfolds in four stages:

1. Idealization
2. Tension accumulation
3. Crisis or abuse
4. Reconciliation

The reconciliation phase restores the externalized structure.

The system returns to equilibrium without addressing the original incompleteness.

Consequently, the cycle repeats.

The relationship becomes self-maintaining because separation threatens the collapse of the compensatory structure.

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## 7. Why Victims Often Return

The persistence of abusive relationships is frequently interpreted as irrational.

From the present framework, however, the behavior is structurally understandable.

Leaving the relationship means losing access to the externalized function.

The compliant partner must confront:

- Personal aggression
- Personal autonomy
- Personal authority

The abusive partner must confront:

- Personal vulnerability

- Personal dependency
- Personal insecurity

Both individuals face the reintegration of functions previously delegated to the relationship.

The resulting anxiety can be greater than the suffering generated by the abuse itself.

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## **8. Integration as Structural Resolution**

The solution is not the replacement of one partner with another.

A new relationship often reproduces the same structure.

The genuine resolution occurs when the externalized function is reintegrated.

The compliant individual develops:

- Assertiveness
- Boundaries
- Capacity for conflict

The abusive individual develops:

- Emotional transparency
- Vulnerability
- Tolerance of dependence

The function previously carried by the relationship becomes internally available.

Local closure is restored.

The external compensatory structure is no longer required.

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## **9. Implications for TNA**

This analysis suggests that Failure of Local Closure is not restricted to mathematics, computation, or language.

The same structural pattern appears in human relationships.

In all cases:

- A system lacks an internally accessible function.
- The function is externalized.
- A boundary condition emerges.
- Stability depends on the external condition.
- Collapse occurs when the condition disappears.

Abusive relationships therefore represent a psychological manifestation of a more general structural principle.

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## 10. Conclusion

The Jungian concept of Shadow projection can be reinterpreted through the framework of TNA as a specific case of Failure of Local Closure.

Abusive relationships persist not merely because of trauma, conditioning, or attachment dysfunction, but because they temporarily solve a structural problem.

Each participant uses the other as an external repository for functions that cannot be consciously integrated.

The resulting stability is real but fundamentally unstable because it depends on a boundary condition external to the individual.

Psychological maturation occurs when the outsourced function is reclaimed and integrated into the self.

The end of the abusive cycle is therefore not merely separation.

It is the restoration of local closure through the internalization of what was previously projected onto another.